

Magic Carpets

A mechanic returns to his deprived village and taps traditional weaving skills to stop migration



SHAMSUDDIN (RIGHT) AT HIS SELF-HELP LOOM

By Amitabh Srivastava

In March 2001, Mohammed Shamsuddin, a mechanical fitter with Eastern Coalfields at Raniganj, West Bengal, came back to his village Jhumarabad, in Jharkhand's Deoghar district. He planned to spend time with his family and children but reality bit hard. He faced a village of migrant workers where the women, children and elders left behind were engaged in a constant struggle to make ends meet. Jhumarabad had no employment avenues, which forced men to leave for Uttar Pradesh, Punjab or Rajasthan to eke out a living. In towns and cities across India, the workers from Jhumarabad lived in pitiable conditions with no assured incomes. "The families were in disarray and everybody was facing emotional distress," recalls Shamsuddin. They wanted to come back but the village had nothing to offer. It was then that he began thinking of a solution.

Shamsuddin soon discovered that the villagers were good at weaving tapestries. He then set up a self-help group with the help of an NGO. The administration too pitched in by building a workshop where looms were set

up. By 2004, the loom started turning out scarves, shawls and woollen mufflers. Still, there was no economic stability though the endeavour did fetch them money and confidence. He kept on looking for marketing opportunities.

Then in 2005, the group hit paydirt when it connected with a Rajasthan-based carpet export company for a deal. It sent trainers to fine-tune the villagers' weaving skills and installed new looms. The village now gets the raw material at the doorstep and the company picks up the finished products, sparing the weavers from marketing issues. Since then, the membership of Shamsuddin's self-help group has doubled to 200.

Today, the men earn more than Rs 3,000 a month each, generating a total income of Rs 6-8 lakh a month from the tapestries. They work in their own village and have enough time for their families. Shamsuddin settles down at the workshop at half-past-eight every day—monitoring and fine-tuning the manufacturing process, besides maintaining records. Apparently, where there is a will, there is a weave.